

I chose my seat, a chair with a nice view of Ben Franklin's behind, as a silent wish for a lucky semester. The class occurred on Tuesdays and Thursdays at 10:30 a.m. (with a lab on Thursday from 6 to 8 p.m.). Entitled C MPU 145: "Foundations of Computer Science" and taught by Professor of Computer Science Anna Gommerstadt, the course is a requirement for all Computer Science majors and correlates. And while it is impossible to know how much I would have enjoyed the class had I chosen it without its use for my major, in this universe, I can affirm it was a heck of a good time.

What exactly did I learn? What is meant by the vague and all-encompassing word "Foundations"? Well, per my trusty syllabus, "This course introduces the theoretical, structural, and algorithmic foundations of computer science." In essence, we learned the basics of functional programming through a language called OCaml. This contrasts with other programming paradigms, like procedural languages or object-oriented languages. Functional programming utilizes functions to solve the problems we face when computing. In both lecture and labs, we developed our skills working with OCaml, proofs, recursive data structures, sets, logic, etc. to assist with higher-level computer science coursework.

I was initially skeptical—from the feedback of others in the department—about how I would fare in our assignments, but I can pleasantly say they are jolly and understandable. Professor Gommerstadt's lectures are engaging and spirited with the energy one needs to understand the intersections and unions of sets. Although one is often searching hard for dry-erase markers in Sanders Physics 105, when all is said and done, the material is interesting and relevant. Even the proofs were not too difficult, just "foundation"-al!

While I suffered from a mid-semester concussion, Professor Gommerstadt was accommodating, and my enjoyment of the lectures kept me on track with the course's workload. Her love of sloths and use of Vim, a text editor, for live lecture coding was a cozy way to pass autumn by. In the labs on Thursday nights, the questions were more puzzle than problem, and our coaches kept us on our toes!

I would recommend anyone take this section, even if they have only the slightest interest in computers and their functioning. It is truly worth a stop on the many twists and turns of a Vassar education.